Harappan cities were laid waste by invaders. The evidence strongly points to the wrath of nature. A number of studies show that the area which is today the Thar desert was once far wetter and that the climate gradually became drier. However, the exact trajectory of this change is somewhat disputed. It is possible that the process of drying was already under way when the Mature Harappan period began. However, around 2200 BC, we find that the monsoons had become distinctly weaker and there were prolonged droughts. In fact, this is a widespread phenomenon that also affected Egypt and Turkey. [7] By itself, this would have caused an agricultural crisis for a heavily populated region. However, the Harappans were hit by an even bigger problem—the drying up of the river system on which the civilization was based.

A simple map of Harappan sites would be enough to illustrate that the largest concentration of settlements is not centred around the Indus but around the dry riverbed of the Ghaggar. It is now little more than a dry riverbed that contains water only after heavy rains (it saw an exceptional flow after the heavy monsoons of 2010). However, surveys and satellite photographs confirm that it was once a great river that rose in the Himalayas, entered the plains in Haryana, flowed through the Thar–Cholistan desert of Rajasthan and eastern Sindh (running roughly parallel to the Indus) and then reached the sea in the Rann of Kutchh in Gujarat. Indeed, the strange marshy landscape of the Rann of Kutchh is partly due to the fact that it was once the estuary of a great river. Although much of this course is now dry desert and often hidden under sand, satellite photographs show that there is still a substantial amount of underground water along the old channels. This has been confirmed by drilling wells that have given fresh water at shallow depths even in the middle of the Thar desert!

The Ghaggar emerges from hills just east of Chandigarh but is joined by a number of other seasonal rivers in the plains of northern Haryana. There is evidence that the Ghaggar and/or some of these rivers were perennial in ancient times. Moreover, satellite images show that both the Sutlej and the Yamuna once flowed into the Ghaggar, which would have made the Ghaggar a mighty river. However, at some point the Ghaggar appears to